

Primary Source Reading: Ogden and Richards, *The Meaning of Meaning*, Chapter VII — “The Meaning of Beauty”

Philosophy Honors: Ethics | Lesson Q1W3 — Do Value-Words Name Anything? Excerpted from C. K. Ogden and I. A. Richards, *The Meaning of Meaning* (7th ed., 1945), pp. 139–159

Before you read:

Recall Socrates' demand of Euthyphro: he wanted “a standard to which I may look, and by which I may measure actions” (6d–e) — some single quality, piety, shared by every pious act. Euthyphro could never produce one. In this chapter, written over two thousand years later, C. K. Ogden and I. A. Richards ask the same question of a different praise-word, “beautiful,” and conclude that no such standard exists — not for want of looking, but because value-words were never in the business of naming a quality at all. Read for the argument in their own words, watching for the distinction they draw between the “symbolic” and “emotive” uses of words, and the place where they say outright that their point about “Beauty” is the same one already made about “Good.”

Epigraph (as printed at the head of the chapter):

“This I have here mentioned by the bye to show of what Consequence it is for Men to define their Words when there is Occasion. And it must be a great Want of Ingenuity (to say no more of it) to refuse to do it: Since a Definition is the only way, whereby the precise Meaning of moral Words can be known.” —Locke

I. The Problem

“In order to test the value of the account of Definition given in the previous chapter, we may best select a subject which has hitherto proved notoriously refractory to definitive methods... What in fact do they mean by Beauty? [Critics], each in his own way dogmatic, enthusiastic and voluminous, each leaves his conclusions equally uncorrelated with those of his predecessors... But if there is no reason to suppose that people are talking about the same thing, a lack of correlation in their remarks need not cause surprise.” (pp. 139–140)

“‘Psychologically,’ [Rupert Brooke] says, ‘they seem to me to be non-starters. In the first place I do not admit the claims of anyone who says “There is such a thing as Beauty,” because when a man says, “This is beautiful,” he does not mean “This is lovely.”... ‘They may mean that the æsthetic emotion exists. My only comments are that it does not follow that the æsthetic emotion does exist; and that, as a matter of fact, they are wrong.’” (p. 141)

II. Word-Superstition

“Beautiful in terms of an intrinsic quality Beauty is in fact an excellent example of the survival of primitive word-superstitions, and of the risks run by any discussion which is symbolically uncritical.” (p. 144)

“If, therefore, terms such as Beauty are used in discussion for the sake of their emotive value, as is usually the case, confusion will inevitably result unless it is constantly realized that words so used are indefinable... Such indefinable uses are no doubt what have often led to the

assumption... of a simple quality of Beauty... as was also suggested above in the case of Good.”
(p. 147)

III. Symbolic Use versus Emotive Use

“In ordinary everyday speech each phrase has not one but a number of functions... here the division between the symbolic use of words and the emotive use [is convenient]. The symbolic use of words is statement; the recording, the support, the organization and the communication of references. The emotive use of words is a more simple matter, it is the use of words to express or excite feelings and attitudes. It is probably more primitive. If we say ‘The height of the Eiffel Tower is 900 feet’ we are making a statement, we are using symbols in order to record or communicate a reference, and our symbol is true or false in a strict sense and is theoretically verifiable. But if we say ‘Hurrah!’ or ‘Poetry is a spirit’ or ‘Man is a worm,’ we may not be making statements, not even false statements; we are most probably using words merely to evoke certain attitudes.”
(pp. 148–149)

“So far as words are used emotively no question as to their truth in the strict sense can directly arise... The best test of whether our use of words is essentially symbolic or emotive is the question — ‘Is this true or false in the ordinary strict scientific sense?’ If this question is relevant then the use is symbolic, if it is clearly irrelevant then we have an emotive utterance.” (p. 150)

“Corresponding in some degree to the strict sense of true and false for symbolic statements (True^S), there are senses which apply to emotive utterances (True^E). Critics often use True^E of works of art, where alternative symbols would be ‘convincing’ in some cases, ‘sincere’ in others, ‘beautiful’ in others, and so on... Further there is a purely evocative use of True — its use to excite attitudes of acceptance or admiration; and a purely evocative use of False — to excite attitudes of distrust or disapprobation.” (p. 151)

IV. What Beauty (and Goodness) Do Instead

“It ought to be impossible to pretend that any scientific statement can give a more inspiring or more profound ‘vision of reality’ than another. It can be more general or more useful, and that is all. On the other hand it ought to be impossible to talk about poetry or religion as though they were capable of giving ‘knowledge.’ A poem — or a religion... has no concern with limited and directed reference. It tells us, or should tell us, nothing. It has a different, though an equally important and a far more vital function — to use an evocative term in connection with an evocative matter. What it does, or should do, is to induce a fitting¹ attitude to experience.” (p. 158)

¹ *Instead of ‘fitting’ we might have said ‘valuable.’ But since the value of an attitude depends in part upon the other attitudes which are possible... we use the term ‘fitting.’”* (p. 158, n. 1)

“It is not necessary to know what things are in order to take up fitting attitudes towards them, and the peculiarity of the greatest attitudes which art can evoke is their extraordinary width. The description and ordering of such attitudes is the business of aesthetics.” (p. 159)

After you read:

Ogden and Richards never call themselves “non-cognitivists,” but their own words make the case: value-words like “beautiful” and “good” do not report facts to be verified, as “the Eiffel Tower is 900 feet” does; they express and evoke attitudes. Recall Euthyphro’s complaint that Socrates left him without a standard for judging new cases (12e). On this account, Socrates may have been chasing something that does not exist. For your discussion post, apply the test — “Is this true or false in the ordinary strict scientific sense?” — to one of Euthyphro’s own sentences, such as “not to prosecute them is impiety” (5d). First, say what a non-cognitivist would claim is really happening when Euthyphro utters it. Second, decide whether this changes what is at stake in his dispute with Socrates, or whether the original question survives the challenge.